

The Diverging American Dream: A Research & Visualization Brief on Inequality, Cost of Living, and Family Formation in the United States, 1960–2026

This brief assembles the narrative architecture, datasets, derived metrics, and visualization plan needed to build an evidence-based data-storytelling website on how U.S. economic conditions have evolved since 1960 — focused on the divergence of cost-of-living burdens by income class and the empirical link between rising costs (especially housing and childcare) and declining birth and family-formation rates.

1. Narrative Arc and Framing

1.1 The most compelling, evidence-based narrative structure

The strongest narrative arc for this topic is a three-act "diverging dream" structure that uses the late 1970s / early 1980s as the pivot point and treats different consumption baskets as winning and losing categories. It works because both the wage-distribution literature (Piketty–Saez–Zucman, EPI Social Security Administration analyses) and the price-divergence literature (Mark Perry's "Chart of the Century," BLS CPI by category) agree that the post-1979 era looks fundamentally different from the post-WWII era for ordinary households.

Act I — "The Shared Boom" (1960 - ~1973): Real median family income roughly doubled between 1947 and 1973. A single-earner household in the bottom or middle quintile could afford a median home, a car, healthcare, and modest college tuition. Marriage rates were near historic highs (about 72% of adults were married in 1960, per Pew/Census), and the total fertility rate was at or above replacement (about 3.65 in 1960, falling to ~2.0 by 1972).

Act II — "The Great Divergence" (1973 – ~2000): The 1973 oil shock, deindustrialization, and the post-1979 redistribution of wages mark a structural break. Per EPI's analysis of Social Security Administration data, from 1979 to 2023 wages for the top 1% rose 181.7% and for the top 0.1% rose 353.9%, while the bottom 90% saw just 43.7% growth. Meanwhile college tuition (per BLS CPI) rose ~1,200% from 1980 onward, and healthcare costs roughly tripled relative to general CPI. Marriage starts to bifurcate by class — Pew's 2010 "Decline of Marriage" report found a 16-percentage-point marriage gap between college graduates and non-graduates by 2008, a gap absent in 1960. (Economic Policy Institute) (Visual Capitalist)

Act III — "The Family-Formation Squeeze" (2000 – present): Mark Perry's "Chart of the Century" shows that between January 2000 and December 2025, hospital services, college tuition, and childcare rose 150–200%+ while TVs, software, toys, and clothing fell. The 2008 housing bubble and the post-2020 housing surge make shelter unaffordable for renters in their childbearing years. The U.S. fertility rate hit a record low of 1.599 in 2024 (CDC NCHS Data Brief 535, July 2025), well below the 2.1 replacement level. Recent quasi-causal research (Couillard 2024–25 at the University of Toronto; Dettling & Kearney 2014 NBER w17485; Lovenheim & Mumford 2013) attributes a substantial share of the fertility decline to housing costs specifically. (NewsNation)

1.2 Most surprising / counterintuitive "aha" moments

These are the findings most likely to land with a general audience:

1. **The "Two CPIs" paradox.** Things you *want* (TVs, clothing, toys, software) became dramatically cheaper since 2000 — TVs fell over 99% in real terms. Things you *need* to form a family (housing, healthcare, childcare, college) rose 150–250%. The American consumer experience is essentially two divergent inflations stacked on the same paycheck. (Human Progress)
2. **The bottom 90% earned 69.8% of all wages in 1979 and just 60.7% in 2023** (EPI). The top 0.1%'s share more than tripled, from 1.6% to 5.2%. (Economic Policy Institute + 2)

3. **Childcare for one infant in a U.S. center now costs more than a year's median rent** in many counties, per the Department of Labor's 2024 National Database of Childcare Prices update.
4. **Married-couple households fell from 71% of all U.S. households in 1970 to 47% in 2022** (Census Bureau, May 2024) — a slower-moving but more consequential change than the headline divorce rate. (Daily Citizen)
5. **Most fertility decline comes from younger women, not older.** Birth rates for women 40–44 *rose* nearly continuously since 1985 (CDC), while rates for women 20–24 hit record lows. People aren't choosing not to have kids — many are running out the biological clock while waiting for economic stability. (CDC)
6. **Couillard (2024)** estimates that if housing costs had remained flat after 1990, ~13 million more children would have been born in the U.S. by 2020, and rising housing costs explain roughly **51% of total fertility decline between the 2000s and 2010s.**
(NewsNation) (Newsweek)
7. **Time prices vs. money prices diverge.** AEI/Human Progress analyses show that, measured in hours of average-wage work, many goods became more affordable even as prices rose — but only for the categories outside the housing/health/education trifecta. This nuance avoids the trap of pure declinism.
8. **The Pew "marriage gap" inverted.** In 1960, marriage rates were similar across class; by 2008, college graduates were ~16 percentage points more likely to be married than non-graduates. Marriage has become a luxury good. (Pew Research Center)
(Pew Research Center)
9. **Pew (2024–25)** found 57% of childless adults under 50 said the main reason they don't expect to have children is "they just don't want to," but a separate Pew analysis (June 2024) showed planned children among adults 20–39 dropped from 2.3 in 2012 to

1.8 in 2023 — a steep drop in just 11 years that maps onto post-2008 housing-cost growth. [Live Action News](#)

1.3 Empirical link between cost of living and fertility — academic & journalistic consensus

There is a growing consensus that **housing costs in particular** are causally important, though not sufficient on their own.

- **Dettling & Cumming (2024 — Federal Reserve Board working paper)** and **Dettling & Kearney (2014, NBER w20208)** find that for renters, a \$10,000 increase in MSA-level home prices reduces fertility ~2.4%; for homeowners, it raises fertility because of a wealth effect. Net effect across the U.S. is negative because most young adults rent. [NBER](#)
- **Lovenheim & Mumford (2013, Review of Economics and Statistics; NBER w17485)** find similar tenure-dependent effects.
- **Couillard (2024-2025, University of Toronto)** estimates that rising housing costs since 1990 caused 11% fewer children and 51% of total fertility-rate decline between the 2000s and 2010s.
- **CEPR (van Doornik et al., 2024)** uses Brazilian housing-credit lotteries to show *causal* (not just correlational) evidence that housing access raises fertility.
- **Institute for Family Studies (Stone)** synthesis: studies of England/Wales (1995-2008), Hong Kong (which attributes 65% of fertility decline since 1971 to housing), and the Netherlands all find negative housing-price effects on renters. [PubMed Central](#)
- **Pew Research Center (2024, 2025)** survey work finds U.S. adults overwhelmingly cite finances — particularly child care, housing, and student debt — when explaining lower planned fertility, with 60% calling free childcare "extremely or very effective" at raising the birth rate. [Archdiocese of San Antonio](#)

The journalistic consensus (NYT, The Atlantic, Vox, Newsweek, and most explicitly the 2025 coverage of the Couillard paper) treats this as one of the most empirically grounded explanations, though it stops short of monocausal claims. The honest framing for the website: **housing and childcare costs are necessary, but not sufficient, explanations.** Cultural shifts (women's education, delayed marriage, individualism) interact with — and in many cases were *enabled by* — the affordability environment. (CEPR)

2. Key Datasets — With Specific Series IDs and Direct URLs

2.1 FRED (Federal Reserve Economic Data, fred.stlouisfed.org)

Income, wages, and inequality

- (MEH0INUSA672N) — Real Median Household Income, U.S. (Census, 1984-present)
(FRED)
- (MEFAINUSA646N) / (MEFAINUSA672N) — Median / Real Median Family Income (back to 1953) (FRED) (FRED)
- (LES1252881600Q) — Median Usual Weekly Real Earnings, full-time workers (1979-present) (FRED)
- (LES1252881900Q) / (LES1252882800Q) — Same, broken out by men / women
- BLS Consumer Expenditure quintile income series on FRED (1984-present):
- (CXUINCBFTXLB0102M) ... (CXUINCBFTXLB0106M) — Income before taxes by quintile (1st through 5th)
- (CXUINCAFTTXLB0102M) ... (CXUINCAFTTXLB0106M) — Income after taxes by quintile
(FRED)

- `CXU900000LB0102M` ... `CXU900000LB0106M` — Wages & salaries by quintile `FRED`
- **Distributional Financial Accounts (Fed wealth data, quarterly 1989–present):**
- `WFRBLT01000` — Total assets held by top 1% `FRED`
- `WFRBSN09139` — Share of financial assets held by 90th–99th percentiles `FRED`
- Companion series available for top 0.1%, next 9%, middle 40%, bottom 50% — see <https://www.federalreserve.gov/releases/efa/efa-distributional-financial-accounts.htm>

CPI components (all monthly, 1947 or later)

- `CPIAUCSL` — All items CPI (the headline) `FRED`
- `CUSR0000SAH1` — Shelter (1953–present) `FRED`
- `CUUR0000SEHA` — Rent of primary residence
- `CPIMEDSL` — Medical Care
- `CUUR0000SEMC` — Hospital services
- `CPIEDUSL` — Education and Communication (1993–present) `FRED`
- `CUUR0000SEEB` — Tuition, other school fees, and childcare (1978–present)
- `CUUR0000SEEB03` — Childcare and nursery school (the most direct "childcare CPI")
- `CUUR0000SEEB01` — College tuition and fees
- `CPIAPPSL` — Apparel
- `CPIFABSL` — Food and Beverages
- `CPITRNSL` — Transportation
- `CUUR0000SS62032` — Toys
- `CUUR0000SERA02` — Televisions
- `CUSR0000SETA01` — New vehicles

- **CUSR0000SETA02** — Used cars and trucks

Housing

- **MSPUS** — Median sales price of houses sold (1963–present, quarterly)
- **CSUSHPINSA** — S&P/Case-Shiller U.S. National Home Price Index (1987–present)
- **USSTHPI** — All-Transactions House Price Index (FHFA, 1975–present, useful for long history)
- **MORTGAGE30US** — 30-year fixed mortgage rate (Freddie Mac, 1971–present)
- **RRVRUSQ156N** — Rental Vacancy Rate
- **HOSMEDUSM052N** and related housing affordability index series

Fertility, births, marriage, population

- **SPDYNTFRTINUSA** — Total Fertility Rate, U.S. (World Bank, 1960–2024). The single most important series for this project. **FRED**
- **SPADOTFRTUSA** — Adolescent Fertility Rate, U.S. **FRED**
- **SPDYNCBRTINUSA** — Crude Birth Rate, U.S.
- FRED's category 33739 (Birth Rate) and 33512 (Fertility Rate) for additional series.

2.2 Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS)

- **Consumer Expenditure Survey, Table 1101 (Quintiles of income before taxes)** — Annual expenditure means by quintile, broken down by category (food, housing, healthcare, transportation, entertainment, etc.). The single most important table for this project. Direct URL: <https://www.bls.gov/cex/tables/calendar-year/mean-item-share-average-standard-error/cu-income-quintiles-before-taxes-2022.pdf> (and

replace the year for prior years; complete archive at

<https://www.bls.gov/cex/tables.htm>). Annual file goes back to 1984; pre-1984 surveys available but methodology is different.

- **CE Tables 1300 (deciles), 1400 (region), 1500 (population size of area)** — for cross-cuts.
- **Annual CE news release** — <https://www.bls.gov/news.release/cesan.htm> — best entry point for current data.
- **CPI detailed indexes** (full archive of all sub-indexes back to varying start dates): <https://www.bls.gov/cpi/data.htm>
- **CPS / Weekly and Hourly Earnings** by demographic breakdowns: <https://www.bls.gov/cps/earnings.htm>

2.3 U.S. Census Bureau

- **Historical Income Tables — Households:** <https://www.census.gov/data/tables/time-series/demo/income-poverty/historical-income-households.html>
- **Table H-1** — Income limits for each fifth of households and top 5% (1967-2024) Govdelivery
- **Table H-2** — Share of aggregate income received by each fifth (1967-2024) Govdelivery
- **Table H-3** — Mean household income by quintile (1967-2024) — the critical inequality-over-time table Govdelivery
- **Table H-4** — Gini ratios (1967-2024) Govdelivery
- **Historical Income Tables — Families:** <https://www.census.gov/data/tables/time-series/demo/income-poverty/historical-income-families.html> (similar tables, 1947-2024)

- **Income in the United States: 2024 (P60-286, September 2025):**
<https://www2.census.gov/library/publications/2025/demo/p60-286.pdf>
- **American Community Survey Table B19080 — Household Income Quintile Upper Limits (county/state geography, 2005–present)** (Census Reporter)
- **CPS ASEC marriage and fertility supplements** — for marriage rate, age at first marriage, never-married percentages
- **Decennial Census + ACS via IPUMS (<https://usa.ipums.org/>)** — best source for individual-level marriage and fertility analysis, 1850–present, free and well-documented.

2.4 CDC / National Center for Health Statistics

- **National Vital Statistics System (NVSS)** — all U.S. births since 1909; used to compute fertility rates by age, race, marital status.
- **Births: Final Data for 2023 (NVSR 74-1, March 2025):**
<https://www.cdc.gov/nchs/data/nvsr/nvsr74/nvsr74-1.pdf>
- **Births in the United States, 2024 (NCHS Data Brief 535, July 2025):**
<https://www.cdc.gov/nchs/data/databriefs/db535.pdf>
- **Vital Statistics Online Data Portal (VitalStats):**
https://www.cdc.gov/nchs/data_access/VitalStatsOnline.htm — public-use natality micro-data files
- **National Survey of Family Growth (NSFG):** <https://www.cdc.gov/nchs/nsfg/> — desired vs. actual fertility, contraception, intentions (Archdiocese of San Antonio)

2.5 Federal Reserve / Survey of Consumer Finances

- **Survey of Consumer Finances (SCF):**

<https://www.federalreserve.gov/econres/scfindex.htm> — triennial 1989–2022, the canonical wealth distribution source. (Congressional Budget Office)

- **Distributional Financial Accounts (DFA):**

<https://www.federalreserve.gov/releases/efa/efa-distributional-financial-accounts.htm> — quarterly wealth shares by percentile group, 1989–present, downloadable as CSV.

(Federal Reserve)

- **CBO Trends in the Distribution of Family Wealth, 1989 to 2022:**

<https://www.cbo.gov/publication/60807>

2.6 Other authoritative sources

- **Department of Labor, National Database of Childcare Prices (NDCP):**

<https://www.dol.gov/agencies/wb/topics/childcare/median-family-income-by-age-care-setting> — county-level childcare prices and prices as share of median family income, 2008–2022.

- **U.S. Treasury, "The Economics of Childcare Supply in the United States" (Sept 2021):** <https://home.treasury.gov/system/files/136/The-Economics-of-Childcare-Supply-09-14-final.pdf>

- **USDA "Expenditures on Children by Families" (the "Cost of Raising a Child" report, annual 1960–2017, then suspended). Latest:** <https://fns-prod.azureedge.us/sites/default/files/resource-files/crc2015-march2017.pdf> — includes 1960-vs-2015 share comparisons (housing was 31% then, 29% now; childcare/education jumped from 2% to 16%). (USDA)

- **Pew Research Center:**

- "Decline of Marriage and Rise of New Families" (Nov 2010):

<https://www.pewresearch.org/social-trends/2010/11/18/the-decline-of-marriage-and-rise-of-new-families/>

- "Having children: What Americans think about declining fertility rates" (Aug 2024): <https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2024/08/02/what-do-americans-think-about-fewer-people-choosing-to-have-children/>
 - "Having fewer kids: Americans' 2025 views" (Sep 2025): <https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2025/09/30/>
 - **National Center for Family & Marriage Research (Bowling Green State University):** <https://www.bgsu.edu/ncfmr.html> — long-run marriage trend data 1900–2022.
 - **Economic Policy Institute (EPI), State of Working America Wage Data:** <https://www.epi.org/publication/swa-wages-2023/> — wage growth by percentile back to 1979.
 - **IPUMS-USA** (<https://usa.ipums.org>) and **IPUMS-CPS** (<https://cps.ipums.org>) — necessary if the project wants individual-level analysis (e.g., birth rate by income decile, marriage rate by education).
 - **Mark Perry "Chart of the Century" (AEI):** <https://www.aei.org/carpe-diem/chart-of-the-day-or-century-6/> — best canonical visualization of the 2000–present "two CPIs" divergence; ideal benchmark/inspiration for one of the website's hero charts.
 - **NBER Working Papers** for academic backing: w17485 (Lovenheim & Mumford 2013), w20208 (Dettling & Kearney 2014), Couillard (2024) on University of Toronto economics working paper repository.
 - **CEPR Vox column on Housing and Fertility (van Doornik et al., 2024):** <https://cepr.org/voxeu/columns/housing-and-fertility>
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3. Visualization Plan

The plan satisfies all requirements: ≥ 2 static, ≥ 2 interactive, ≥ 1 linked view, ≥ 1 infographic,

plus dashboard, map, and temporal elements.

3.1 Hero static visualization — "The Two Americas of Inflation"

Chart type: Multi-line chart (Mark Perry "Chart of the Century" style), all categories indexed to 100 in 1960 (or 2000 if pre-1980 data is sparse), with red lines (housing, hospital services, college tuition, childcare) above and blue lines (TVs, toys, clothing, software) below. Average wages drawn as a thick black reference line. **Data:** FRED CPI sub-indexes ([CUSR0000SAH1](#), [CUUR0000SEMD](#), [CUUR0000SEEB01](#), [CUUR0000SEEB03](#), [CPIAPPSL](#), [CUUR0000SERA02](#), etc.) and [CES0500000003](#) for average hourly earnings. **The "aha":** A general audience can see, in a single image, that family-formation costs and consumer-electronics costs went in opposite directions.

3.2 Static visualization — "Marriage and Fertility Have Cracked Open by Class"

Chart type: Small-multiples slope graph: in 1960 vs. 2020, marriage rate by education quartile, fertility rate by income quintile, never-married rate by education. **Data:** IPUMS CPS for individual-level slicing; supplemented by Pew's 2010 marriage-by-class table. **The "aha":** In 1960 there was virtually no class gradient in marriage. Today it is enormous.

3.3 Interactive #1 — "Build Your 1960 vs. 2025 Household"

Chart type: Slope/parallel-coordinates "personal calculator" that, given user inputs (income decile, region, family size, owner/renter), draws lines connecting how that household's budget for housing, food, healthcare, childcare, and college would look in 1960 vs. today as a share of income. **Data:** BLS CE Survey Table 1101 (quintiles), USDA Cost of Raising a Child series, FRED [MEH0INUSA672N](#), Department of Labor NDCP for childcare. **Why:** It personalizes the inequality story; users see whether their cohort "won" or "lost" the diverging dream.

3.4 Interactive #2 — "The Affordability Gap, by County"

Chart type: Choropleth map of the U.S., toggleable between (a) median home price ÷ median household income, (b) infant childcare price ÷ median family income, (c) rent burden, (d) total cost-of-children index. A time-slider scrubs across years (2008–2022 for childcare; 1985–present for housing). **Data:** DOL NDCP county file (CSV available at the [dol.gov](#) link above), Census ACS (B19013) (median household income), Zillow ZHVI or FHFA HPI for housing. **Why:** Map view is required by the brief; the geographic divergence (coastal/urban vs. interior) is dramatic and shows that "national averages" hide the affordability crisis.

3.5 Linked view (interaction in one chart updates another) — "Scrub Time, Watch the Dream Diverge"

Design: Place three coordinated charts on one page:

1. A horizontal time slider running 1960 → 2026.
2. **Top panel:** Stacked-area chart of the share of income spent by a middle-quintile household on housing, food, healthcare, childcare, education, transportation, and "everything else." Slider controls the displayed year, with a small line above showing the trajectory.
3. **Middle panel:** Bar chart of real wage *growth since 1979* by percentile (10th, 50th, 90th, 99th, 99.9th), updating as the slider moves.
4. **Bottom panel:** Single-number readout + sparkline of the U.S. total fertility rate for that year, with the replacement-rate line (2.1) drawn for reference. **Data:** EPI/SSA wage percentile series, BLS CE Table 1101 historical, FRED (SPDYNTFRTINUSA). **Why:** Lets the viewer *feel* the temporal correlation between rising cost-share, stagnant bottom-90% wages, and falling fertility — without imposing causality.

3.6 Infographic — "The Cost of a Child, 1960 → 2025"

Design: A vertical scrollytelling infographic following one symbolic child from birth through age 18. At each life stage, show the real-dollar cost of: a hospital delivery (~\$11,000 in 2000 → ~\$28,000 in 2020 per AHRQ), one year of infant childcare in a center (~\$0 in the imagined 1960 single-earner household → ~\$15,600 average / \$24,000 in DC in 2022), K-12 incidental costs, a year of in-state public college tuition (\$358 in 1969-70 → ~\$9,750 in 2022, before adjusting for inflation), and total estimated child-rearing costs (USDA: \$25,000 in 1960 dollars vs. \$233,610 nominal for a child born in 2015, ~\$310,000 inflation-adjusted projected lifetime). **Data:** USDA Expenditures on Children by Families (1960 and 2015 reports), CPI for hospital services, college tuition CPI, DOL NDCP. **Why:** A scrollytelling infographic gives narrative shape and emotional weight; it's the part most likely to be shared. (USAFacts + 2)

3.7 Dashboard — "The American Dream Index"

Design: Single-page dashboard with KPI cards:

- Real median household income (FRED (MEH0INUSA672N))
- Years of median income to buy median home ((MSPUS) ÷ (MEH0INUSA672N))
- Hours of average-wage work to afford one year of public college ((CUUR0000SEEB01) ÷ (CES05000000003))
- Childcare cost as % of median family income (NDCP)
- U.S. total fertility rate vs. replacement ((SPDYNTFRTINUSA) minus 2.1)
- Top 1% wage share (EPI/SSA) Each card shows a sparkline 1960-present and a "vs. 1960" delta. **Why:** Satisfies dashboard requirement; gives entry-points to deeper sections.

3.8 Temporal visualization — Animated horizon chart of CPI categories

Chart type: A horizon plot or animated racing-bar chart showing CPI sub-indexes 1960 → 2026, sorted by current rank. **Why:** Makes the *order* of the price divergence visceral — childcare, healthcare, college, housing race ahead while clothing and electronics fall behind.

4. Key Metrics to Calculate (Derived Indicators)

These derived measures are far more powerful than raw series and have established journalistic and academic precedent.

1. **Real cost growth indexed to 1960 = 100** for each CPI category. Standard practice; makes the divergence visually intuitive.
2. **"Hours of work to afford X"** (the time-price methodology popularized by Mark Perry, Gale Pooley, and HumanProgress.org). Compute: (nominal price of X at year t) ÷ (average hourly wage at year t). Apply to: a year of public college tuition, median home, year of infant childcare, average hospital delivery, gallon of gas, dozen eggs, refrigerator. The website should compute this for *both* the average wage **and** the 20th-percentile wage to expose the inequality dimension Perry's chart skips.
3. **Years-to-home-purchase ratio:** Median home price ÷ median household income ($\text{MSPUS} / \text{MEH0INUSA672N}$). Was ~2.0 in 1960, now ~5–7. Single most cited housing-affordability metric.
4. **Childcare cost as % of median family income** (DOL methodology; HHS affordability threshold = 7%, so flag the share of counties above 7%, 10%, 20%).

U.S. Department of the Tre... Federal Reserve Bank of C...
5. **Cost of children as multiple of annual household income** (USDA total ÷ annual income) — has roughly *doubled* relative to earnings for middle-quintile families since 1960.

6. **Class-divergence ratios:**

- Top 1% / median wage ratio (was $\sim 9\times$ in 1979, $\sim 19\times$ in 2022 per EPI)
 - 90/10 income ratio (Census Table A-3) — was $\sim 9\times$ in 1967, $\sim 13\times$ recently (Census)
 - Top 0.1% wealth share (DFA) — roughly tripled since 1989
7. **"Necessity inflation" vs. "discretionary inflation":** Build a custom price index that weights only housing, healthcare, childcare, education, and food, vs. one that weights only durables, apparel, and electronics. Plot the spread — this is the story.
 8. **Fertility-housing elasticity:** Following Dettling & Kearney's framework, regress state-level birth rate changes on FHFA HPI changes 1985–present, separately for renters and owners. Replicates published findings on free, public data.
 9. **"Bachelor of regret" gap:** Difference between desired family size (NSFG) and actual completed fertility (NVSS) — has widened since 2000 and is the strongest evidence that fertility decline is not driven by changing preferences alone.
 10. **Marriage gap by class:** Pew-style decomposition of marriage rates by education and income quintile, 1960 $\rightarrow$ present.
 11. **"Single earner sufficient" share:** Percentage of married-couple households where one earner can cover median budget for family of four; collapsed from majority in 1960 to small minority today.

5. **What the Data Will Actually Show — Expected Findings**

A student building this site honestly should expect their analysis to converge on the following, all of which are well-supported in the existing literature:

5.1 What got more affordable since 1960

- **Tradable goods.** Apparel, food at home, household furnishings, appliances, electronics, toys, and new vehicles all became cheaper relative to wages. Mark Perry's analysis using BLS data shows TVs fell over 99% in time-price terms since 2000; clothing fell roughly 30% in real terms since the early 1990s. (Human Progress)
- **Communications.** Phone service, internet, and information goods became dramatically cheaper.
- **Food (commodity portion).** USDA data show food fell from a substantially larger share of household budgets in 1960 (over 17%) to about 11-13% today; food at home in particular fell relative to income.
- **Air travel and entertainment access.**

5.2 What got dramatically less affordable

- **Hospital services and medical care:** roughly 200%+ increase relative to general CPI since 2000.
- **College tuition and fees:** up ~1,200% since 1980 vs. ~236% for general CPI; the most extreme price divergence in BLS data. (Visual Capitalist)
- **Childcare and nursery school:** tracking 2-3× general CPI since 1990; share of family income for an infant in center-based care now ranges 8.9%-29% depending on county (DOL NDCP 2022). (U.S. Department of Labor)
- **Housing:** Real home prices roughly **doubled** since 1960 (Case-Shiller / FHFA), while real household income rose only ~50%. The price-to-income ratio for the median home rose from ~2× to ~5-7×. Rents rose 149% from 1990 to 2020 vs. 103% general inflation (Couillard / BLS). (Newsweek) (The MortgagePoint -)
- **Property taxes and insurance.** Particularly post-2020.

5.3 Who gained and who lost

- **Top 1% gained spectacularly.** Wages up 181.7% since 1979 (EPI); top 0.1% up 353.9%. Top 1% wealth share roughly doubled. (Economic Policy Institute) (Economic Policy Institute)
- **Top 10% (excluding the top 1%) gained modestly.** Real wage growth around 50–80% since 1979. (Economic Policy Institute)
- **Bottom 90% nearly stagnated in wages** (43.7% over 44 years, or under 1% per year), with most of that growth concentrated post-2014. (Economic Policy Institute)
- **Bottom 50% in wealth own about 2% of national wealth** (Survey of Consumer Finances 2022); top 10% own about 73%. (People's Policy Project) (People's Policy Project)
- **Within the bottom 90%, who you are matters enormously.** College graduates pulled away from non-graduates in wages, marriage rates, and wealth. The "marriage gap" by education widened from near zero in 1960 to ~16 percentage points today.
- **Renters lost more than homeowners** in the post-1990 housing boom; home equity is the single largest form of wealth for the middle class, and homeownership rates among adults under 35 fell by roughly 10 percentage points since 1980.
- **Mothers as a class face a "double-bind":** rising female labor-force participation and wages were partly offset by rising childcare costs, especially for low-income single mothers (childcare can consume 30–49% of income for some Black single-mother households per United Way analyses). (United Way NCA)

5.4 The fertility-and-family findings

- **U.S. total fertility rate:** 3.65 in 1960 → 2.48 in 1970 → 2.05 in 1990 → 2.12 in 2007 (post-recession peak) → **1.599 in 2024**, the lowest in U.S. history (CDC NCHS Data Brief 535, July 2025). The post-2007 decline is unusually steep and broad-based. (NewsNation)

- **Number of births fell 17% from 2007 (most recent peak) to 2023** (CDC NVSR 74-1).
- **Teen birth rate (15-19) fell ~67% since 2007** — almost the entire decline in fertility for women under 25 is from teens, who are the most economically constrained group.
- **Birth rate for women 40-44 rose almost continuously since 1985** — confirming that delayed, not foregone, fertility explains a major share of the trend. (CDC)
- **Married-couple share of households fell from 71% (1970) to 47% (2022)** (Census, 2024). Median age at first marriage rose by 6+ years since 1960. (USA Facts)
- **Pew (June 2024):** Among adults 20-39, planned children fell from 2.3 (2012) to 1.8 (2023) — well below replacement. The decline is concentrated among college-educated women. (Live Action News) (Live Action News)
- **Couillard (2024):** Roughly **51% of fertility decline between the 2000s and 2010s, and approximately 11% fewer total children since 1990, are attributable to housing-cost increases.** Multiple corroborating studies (Dettling & Kearney 2014, Lovenheim & Mumford 2013, van Doornik et al. 2024) reach broadly consistent conclusions on the housing channel.
- **Brigham Young University 2025 American Family Survey:** 71% disagreed that "having children is affordable for most people"; 43% of those not planning more children cited finances vs. only 22% citing lack of personal desire. (The Hill)

5.5 The honest synthesis the website should land on

The data support — and a careful student analysis will arrive at — a narrative roughly like this:

Since 1960, the average American has gotten dramatically richer in things they want (electronics, clothing, food variety, communications) and dramatically poorer in things they need to start a family (housing, healthcare, childcare, education). For the top 10%, rising wages and asset values more than compensated; for the bottom 90%, wage

stagnation collided with surging costs in exactly the categories that most affect family formation. The result is a delayed-and-foregone fertility crisis in which most Americans want more children than they have, and the gap between desired and achieved family size has widened in lockstep with housing and childcare costs.

This framing — careful about causation, honest about the role of cultural change, but unflinching about the cost-divergence data — is well-supported by the FRED, BLS, Census, CDC, Pew, Federal Reserve, and peer-reviewed academic sources cited above, and is the most defensible thesis for a scholarship project of this scope.

Caveats and Methodological Notes

A few caveats the student should acknowledge in the published site:

- **CPI index choice matters.** "Hospital services" CPI is widely criticized as understating actual healthcare-price growth because it tracks list prices imperfectly. Using national health expenditures (CMS NHE data) as a triangulating series is recommended.
- **CE Survey income quintile boundaries shift over time.** When comparing 1984 vs. 2024 quintiles, real-dollar boundary changes mean the "lowest quintile" in 1984 is not directly the same population as in 2024. Best practice: report shares of total income/expenditure, not absolute dollar comparisons, when possible.
- **TFR vs. completed fertility.** Total fertility rate is a synthetic period measure that *over-states* fertility decline when births are merely delayed. Cohort completed fertility (which lags by ~20 years) is a more conservative measure; the website should ideally show both.
- **Causation vs. correlation in the housing-fertility link.** The Couillard estimate of 51% comes from a structural model with assumptions; it should be reported as "model-estimated" rather than as a direct empirical finding. The natural-experiment evidence

(van Doornik et al., Brazilian credit lottery) is the strongest causal evidence and worth flagging. [Newsweek](#) [CEPR](#)

- **The Mark Perry "Chart of the Century"** is widely cited but starts in 2000, missing the most important period (1980s–90s) for the inequality story. The site should extend it backward using the same FRED CPI sub-indexes to cover the full 1960–present arc.

With these datasets, derived metrics, and the "Diverging Dream" narrative arc, the resulting visualization site should produce a rigorous, original, and emotionally resonant story about how the American economy reshaped itself across two generations — and what that has meant for the families that came of age within it.